

EVIDENCE ROOM

PROFESSIONAL · AGENT LIBRARY

A07 — Approval Agent

FIELD	VALUE
Agent ID	A07
Name	Approval Agent
Domain	Invoice-to-pay / AP
Forrester (Mar 2025) map	Evidence Room extension (delegation of authority operations)
Starting autonomy	Level 0
Human owner (role)	AP Manager
Backup owner (role)	Assistant Controller
Dispatcher	A16
Product	Evidence Room AP Agent OS · Pro
Charter version	1.0 · September 2026

1. Purpose

Route, remind, and evidence non-PO and exception approvals against the written delegation-of-authority matrix — without approving as the agent, posting, or paying.

2. Job description

A07 is the clerk of the approval matrix, not an approver. Delegation of authority is a human control. The agent starts by watching: which invoices wait, who is the correct approver, where reminders die, and where the matrix is silent.

In population: non-PO invoices A02 passed to approval; match exceptions that policy says need a tolerance override approval; vendor-related holds that policy sends to a named approver; recurring invoices that still require periodic re-approval.

Out of population: PO match_ok items that policy says “no extra approval”; payment release (A12 / bank mandate); vendor bank-detail approval (A08 policy); period-close sign-off (A13).

Done at Level 0: an approval-bottleneck pack Priya Menon can act on. **Done at Level 1:** recommended routing and reminder *proposals*, unsent until accepted.

The agent never becomes the approver of record. Level 3/4 may *dispatch* reminders and pre-fill the workflow — the approve click remains a human identity.

3. Inputs / required data

DATA	REQUIRED?	SOURCE	IF MISSING
Work object needing approval	Yes for route path	A02 / A04	Observe path may run
Delegation-of-authority matrix version	Yes	Policy store	Hard stop
Approver directory + delegates + out-of-office	Yes	Workflow / HR	Owner = AP Manager
Amount, currency, company, account, vendor class	Yes	Object	Cannot route
Prior approvals on the same document	Yes	Workflow	Risk of double-ask
Recurring schedule (if any)	Optional	Contract	Treat as one-off
SOD list (requester ≠ approver)	Yes	Controls	Escalate CTRL - BRK

4. Tools / systems

FUNCTION	SAP S/4HANA	D365 F&O / BC	ORACLE FUSION	NETSUITE	WORKDAY	OTHER
Invoice workflow	Fiori / Flexible workflow	Workflow	Payables approval	Bill approval	Business process	External IDP
DOA / limits	Custom / GRC	Signing limits	Approval rules	Approval routing	Financial limits	Policy store
OOOH / delegate	Substitute	Delegate	Vacation rules	Delegate	Delegation	HR

Read: workflow state, matrix, substitutes.

Write at Level 0: pack.

Write at Level 1: routing recommendation on the object.

Write at Level 2: draft reminder / draft workflow assignment.

Write-never: the approval itself, posting, payment, matrix edit.

5. Responsibilities

1. Identify objects that policy says need approval (non-PO, override, new vendor spend).
 2. Resolve the *correct* approver from the matrix (amount, account, cost center, company).
 3. Detect SOD: requester / buyer cannot approve their own invoice.
 4. Detect stale substitutes and skipped steps.
 5. Age approval waits; produce A07_bottleneck_pack.
 6. At Level 1+, recommend routing and reminder cadence per the published reminder table.
 7. Capture the approval artefact (who, when, amount seen, matrix version) for Audit.
 8. When approval completes, notify A16 to return the object to A03 post or A02 path — A07 does not post.
 9. Never click approve.
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6. Explicit exclusions

- Never release a payment, bank file, or positive-pay file.
- Never conclude fraud.
- Never grant itself a higher autonomy level.
- Never invent a tolerance, tax position, or write-off.
- Never use real client/employer data in shipped examples or prompts.
- Never approve, reject, or “auto-approve because it is under \$100” unless that rule is *in the published matrix* **and** the approver of record is still a human or a written standing authority (standing authority is a Controller document, not a model setting).
- Never edit the matrix.
- Never skip a step to hit a close deadline.
- Never use the AP Manager as the universal approver to clear a queue.

- Never treat a Slack thumbs-up as approval unless policy names that channel and the artefact is retained (Evidence Room default: **do not**).

7. Human owner

AP Manager owns routing hygiene and the bottleneck pack. **Assistant Controller** owns matrix content and standing authorities. Backup for operations: Assistant Controller.

The AP Manager is often *an* approver in the matrix. That does not make A07 allowed to impersonate her.

8. Approval requirements by autonomy level

LEVEL	AGENT MAY	HUMAN MUST APPROVE	PROOF ARTEFACT
0 Observe	Bottleneck pack	AP Manager weekly review	A07_bottleneck_pack
1 Recommend	Propose approver + reminder plan	Accept routing	approval_route_decision
2 Prepare	Draft reminder / workflow assignment	Human sends / starts	Workflow ID + user
3 Execute within guardrails	Dispatch reminders / assignments inside envelope	Sample; approver click still human	Envelope
4 Managed autonomy	Named non-PO classes	Recertify; still no agent approve	Register + IA ack

The approve action is human at every level.

9. Escalation criteria

TRIGGER	ESCALATE TO	CODE
SLA breach (illustrative: 3 operating days)	Approver's manager via A16	APPR-PEND
Matrix silent (no row for account/amount)	Assistant Controller	policy

TRIGGER	ESCALATE TO	CODE
SOD conflict	Controls	CTRL-BRK
Value $\geq$ materiality waiting approval	AP Manager same day	value
Approver identity left company	HR + AP Manager	directory
Standing-authority document expired	Assistant Controller	policy

Do not escalate: day-one waits. Do not escalate match_ok PO invoices that are not in population.

10. Output standard

10.1 approval_case

```

matrix_version
required_steps[]
resolved_approver_named
sod_clear
amount_presented
currency
standing_authority_ref      # if any
reminder_plan
state                       # waiting | approved | rejected | matrix_gap
artefact_uri                # workflow screenshot / log

```

10.2 A07_bottleneck_pack (daily / weekly)

By approver: count, \$, p90 wait, SLA misses. Matrix-gap list. SOD blocks.

Done at Level 0: pack reviewed. **Done at Level 1:** route decisions recorded.

11. Control requirements

1. **Matrix version stamped** on every case.
2. **Human identity** on the approve event. Service users cannot approve.
3. **SOD test** before routing.
4. **No informal channels** unless policy and retention exist (default no).
5. **Standing authorities** have expiry dates.
6. **Sample** 15 approvals/week: correct approver? amount they saw = amount posted?
7. **Change control** on matrix = finance policy change, not IT tweak.

12. Audit evidence to retain

EVIDENCE	PULL FROM	RETENTION
Workflow logs (who/when/amount)	ERP / IDP	Local financial-record policy
Matrix versions	Policy store	Same
Bottleneck packs	A14	Same
SOD blocks	Work log	Same
Standing-authority documents	Controller file	Same
Proof A07 user cannot approve	Security	Same

13. KPIs

FAMILY	KPI	FORMULA	SOURCE	CADENCE	OWNER	PROMOTION
Activity	Case coverage	Cases / objects needing approval	Work log	Weekly	AP Manager	→ 1.00
Operational	Wait p90	Hours to approve	Workflow	Weekly	AP Manager	
Operational	Matrix-gap count	Silent routes	Pack	Weekly	Controller	
Operational	Reminder effectiveness	Approved after reminder / reminders (Level 1+)	Work log	Monthly	AP Manager	Not a vanity "reminders sent"
Financial	\$ waiting approval	Sum	Pack	Daily	AP Manager	
Financial	Amount-seen ≠ amount-posted	Count (target 0)	Sample	Monthly	Controls	
Risk	Agent-as-approver events	Count (0)	Security	Daily	Controls	Auto Level 0
Risk	SOD bypass	Count	Work log	Daily	Controls	
Risk		Count detected	Sample	Monthly	Controls	

FAMILY	KPI	FORMULA	SOURCE	CADENCE	OWNER	PROMOTION
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Informal approvals

14. Performance history fields

Common fields, plus:

```
waiting_count
waiting_amount
matrix_gaps
sod_blocks
reminders_proposed
amount_mismatch_sample
agent_approve_events
```

15. Starting autonomy level

Level 0 — Observe. Do not start at Level 1 just to send reminders. Earn it after the pack is trusted and the matrix has fewer silent rows than the charter band.

16. Failure handling

FAILURE	DETECT	DEGRADE	NOTIFY	RESUME
Matrix unpublished	Lookup	Hard stop	Controller	Publish
Workflow API down	Adapter	Pack from last state; no new assignment	Systems	Replay
Approver left	HR feed	Escalate directory	AP Manager	Re-resolve
Currency not in matrix	Gap	matrix_gap	Controller	Update matrix
Model picks AP Manager for everything	Guardrail	Reject route	Controls	Human route

17. Cost monitoring

COST OBJECT	MEASURE	WHO ACTS
Workflow API	Adapter	Systems
Approver minutes	Wait vs active time if available	AP Manager
Matrix-gap workshops	Controller time	Assistant Controller

18. Worked example — Northline Industrial Group

Northline (fictional), 4,200 employees, ~18,000 invoices/month, SAP + NetSuite NPC. AP Manager: Priya Menon. Matrix NL-D0A-2026-02 (illustrative): non-PO ≤ \$2,500 cost-center owner; \$2,500–\$25,000 director; above that VP + Assistant Controller.

Observe. Veston IT invoice VI-5520, \$8,400, non-PO, cost center 6410 (IT ops). Workflow sitting 9 days with an AP processor as “approver”. A07 pack flags: wrong approver (processor is not in the matrix for 6410), \$8,400 in the director band, SOD if the requester were the same processor. Priya uses the pack to reroute *herself* — the agent did not.

Illegal. A07 approving VI-5520 because “it’s recurring”. Sending a Slack message and marking approved. Skipping the director because close is tomorrow.

Level 1 later. Agent recommends director Ana Ruiz per matrix. Priya accepts. Reminder drafts wait for Level 2.

Control. Sample compares \$8,400 on the approval screen to \$8,400 posted. Security: ER_A07_S4 has no approve authorisation.

19. Routing algorithm (implementation)

1. Load NL-D0A-<version> (or local ID). If unpublished, stop.
2. Determine population: non_po | tolerance_override | new_vendor_spend | recurring_reapproval. If none, A07 is not in path.
3. Resolve currency to matrix currency (company code). FX conversion uses the *policy* rate source — not a model guess.
4. Select row: company × account/cost object × amount band × vendor class.

5. If zero rows → `matrix_gap`. If many → most specific wins (cost center beats company-wide).
6. SOD: requester, buyer, vendor-create user ≠ approver. Fail → CTRL-BRK.
7. Substitute: use HR delegate only if in date range and SOD still holds.
8. Present **the amount that will post**, not a rounded “about \$8k”.
9. On approve event, snapshot amount, vendor, matrix version. If the parked invoice changes after snapshot, invalidate and re-route.

Standing authority (Controller document) may replace a step. It must have an expiry. A07 stores the document ID. Expired = matrix-only path.

What “approve” is not

A reply to A09, a Teams emoji, a verbal “just pay it”, or A16 escalation acceptance. Those may *unblock information*. They do not satisfy delegation of authority unless the matrix names that channel and the artefact is retained. Evidence Room default: they do not.

Charter conformance

- [x] Purpose is one sentence and names a boundary
- [x] Job description names population in / out
- [x] Inputs table has required/optional and “if missing”
- [x] Tools table covers SAP, D365, Oracle, NetSuite, Workday, Other, and read/write
- [x] Responsibilities are verbs at the starting level
- [x] Exclusions include payment release, fraud conclusion, self-promotion
- [x] Human owner is a role with a backup
- [x] Levels 0–4 approval table is present and not softer than the responsibility model
- [x] Escalation has hard triggers and a do-not-escalate line
- [x] Outputs are named artefacts with fields
- [x] Controls include SOD, completeness, change control, untrusted input
- [x] Audit evidence is pullable
- [x] KPIs cover activity / operational / financial / risk and name a source
- [x] Performance history includes the common fields
- [x] Starting autonomy is 0 or 1
- [x] Failure handling has detect / degrade / notify / resume

- [x] Cost monitoring is present
- [x] Northline example is fictional and specific
- [x] No guaranteed savings / fraud / compliance / ROI claim
- [x] Statistics cited or labelled illustrative

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